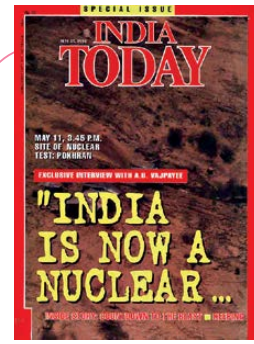
NUCLEAR BOMB TESTS

.86
TONNES

India's stockpile of weapons grade plutonium by 2023-end, enough for 100-150 nuclear warheads, according to the International Panel on Fissile Material

DID YOU KNOW?

India previously possessed chemical weapons, but voluntarily destroyed its entire stockpile (1,045 tonnes of sulphur mustard) in 2009—the third country, after South Korea and Albania, to do so in meeting the deadline set by the Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons



FROM THE ARCHIVES
May 25, 1998

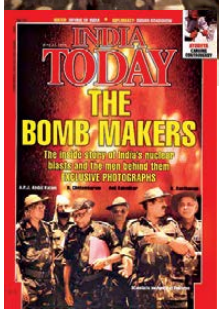
Cover Story
Nuclear Shock Waves

For the six men who assembled in the sitting room of the Prime Minister's official residence at Race Course Road that Monday afternoon, it was a tense wait. As three simultaneous nuclear explosions rocked the scorching sands of the Pokharan test range in the Rajasthan desert at 3.45 pm, the only sound they heard was the purring of the air conditioner. Exactly 10 minutes later, the phone rang in an adjoining room. The Prime Minister's Principal Secretary Brajesh Mishra lifted the receiver to hear an excited voice cry "Done!" Putting the caller on hold, Mishra re-entered the room. Seeing the expression, Vajpayee, Home Minister L.K. Advani, Defence Minister George Fernandes, Finance Minister Yashwant Sinha...could barely control their feelings. Picking up the receiver, Vajpayee, thanked the two scientists who made it happen—Department of Atomic Energy chief R. Chidambaram and head of the Defence Research and Development Organisation A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

-Manoj Joshi



MASTERLY DECEPTION
India's top nuclear and defence scientists wore military fatigues to fool US surveillance satellites before and during the 1998 tests



FROM THE ARCHIVES
June 22, 1998

Cover Story
The Bomb Makers

In their battlefield fatigues they appeared like ageing heroes in a Bollywood potboiler as they sat waiting and sweating in the control room—a bunker littered with computers and control panels. One panel activated by a key started a timer which at 9 am on May 11 would have sent a tiny electrical current to trigger explosions that would shake the world. R. Chidambaram, Atomic Energy Commission chairman, dressed as Maj. Gen. Natraj, removed his Gorkha hat to stop the sweat from streaming down his face.

-Raj Chengappa

TO THE POWER OF N

» Operation Shakti gave clarity to India's nuclear doctrine, with PM Vajpayee telling Parliament that it will be centred on a small but credible deterrent and a no-first-use policy

» The 2008 India-US nuclear deal enables the US to share civilian nuclear technology, while allowing India to keep military grade reactors for its weapons programme

» In 2014, India and Russia signed an agreement for joint construction of 12 nuclear power plants in India

» INS *Arihant*, the first indigenous nuclear submarine commissioned in 2016

destroying India's nuclear forces in a first-strike attack by ensuring the launch of a second strike.

India, however, has excellent non-proliferation credentials and is pledged to a policy of 'no first use' against nuclear weapon states and 'non-use against non-nuclear weapon states'. This, and India's determined assertion of its right to challenge the existing nuclear apartheid, gradually ended the isolation from the global nuclear order and redefined India's terms of engagements with the world. ■